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7-Night Thanksgiving Caribbean: Hosted Solo Group

Norwegian Escape · 7 Nights from Port Canaveral

November 20 to 27, 2026 · Thanksgiving Cruise · Hosted by Pam Walters



Norwegian Escape on the water near Nassau, Bahamas, seen broadside from a beach, with her name on the hull and sea-life hull art. Photo by Syrus257 (CC BY 2.0) via Wikimedia Commons.

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**
Hosted by Pam Walters · **Thanksgiving Group Cruise Facebook chat**

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Welcome

> *Made for the solo travelers in Pam's Thanksgiving group, and for anyone else on this sailing who wants one plain read on the week: the ship, the four stops, Thanksgiving Day, and what to check before you go.*

This pack is about one cruise: **Norwegian Escape**, Norwegian Cruise Line, sailing 7 nights round trip from **Port Canaveral, Friday November 20 to Friday November 27, 2026**. NCL calls it a "7-Day Eastern Caribbean from Orlando (Port Canaveral)." She calls at **Puerto Plata (Amber Cove), St. Thomas, Tortola and Great Stirrup Cay**, with two sea days. **Thanksgiving Day, Thursday November 26, is your day at Great Stirrup Cay**, and the evening is back on board.

It's a **hosted solo cruisers group** led by **Pam Walters**. The group talks in the **Thanksgiving Group Cruise Facebook chat**. Join it before you sail: that's where Pam posts the sailaway meeting spot, the group dinner plans and the daily where-are-we-meeting notes. Once you're aboard, Pam is the one to find in person. For booking questions, and what your group rate includes, ask your travel agent; for this group that's **Tina Maulsby** of Maulsby Travel.

Your ship comes out of a refresh just before you sail. NCL's own Escape page says the ship is "getting an exciting new refresh coming late October": an expanded Vibe Beach Club, a new restaurant called Palomar, a Starbucks in the Atrium and a pickleball court. Cruise Industry News reported in October 2026 that she'd spend 16 days in a European shipyard, then cross back to start her Caribbean season from Port Canaveral in mid-November. Your sailing is the second of those Caribbean weeks, so some of what's new will still be new to the crew too. Check the app for what's open.

A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

I haven't sailed Norwegian Escape. Pam and Tina know this group and this kind of cruise first-hand; I don't, so where they tell you something different, go with them. This pack comes from NCL's own pages (its schedule for this exact sailing, its ship page, its "What's On Board" page, its deck plans, its FAQ and its press releases), Port

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Canaveral's own site, and government pages for each stop. Where only a travel site or a newspaper had the answer, the pack says so. Where nobody had it, the pack says that too. The fact-check file behind this pack lists what was checked and where.

Prices and policies here were checked in October 2026, five weeks before you sail. NCL can change them. Where this pack and the NCL app disagree, go with the app.

It is calm by design. No urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent: no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. (See our **affiliate disclosure**.)

A note on the season. NOAA's National Hurricane Center says the Atlantic hurricane season runs June 1 to November 30, so your whole week falls inside it, right at the end. NOAA adds that tropical cyclone activity "sometimes occurs before and after these dates." Travel insurance still makes sense.

Includes an Emergency Contacts section with a fillable handoff card to leave with one trusted person at home. The companion app keeps the card on your phone, and it works offline once it's loaded.

If this is your first time sailing solo, the **solo cruising stories on this site** are worth a read before you go.

At a Glance

Ship	**Norwegian Escape**, the first ship of NCL's Breakaway Plus class
Cruise line	Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
Size	164,998 gross tons (a measure of enclosed volume, not weight) · 1,069 ft long, per NCL
Guests and crew	4,218 guests at two to a cabin, and 1,733 crew, per NCL's ship page. That's about 2.4 guests for every crew member

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Built by	Meyer Werft, Papenburg, Germany. Handed over October 22, 2015. NCL announces a refresh in late October 2026
Departure port	**Port Canaveral**, Florida. NCL says it “typically” sails from Cruise Terminal 5 or 6; your eDocs name yours
Itinerary	7 nights · Eastern Caribbean, round trip
Traveling	Solo, in Pam Walters’s hosted group
Group host	Pam Walters, via the **Thanksgiving Group Cruise Facebook chat**
Group rates	Solo Studio $1,249 · Ocean View $1,569 · Balcony $1,839, from the group’s original flyer. Check yours with Tina
Currency aboard	US dollar

Ports of call

These are the times on NCL’s own schedule for this sailing (voyage 23369102), read October 2026. **They are ship’s times. Check them in the NCL app before you sail.**

1. **Port Canaveral, Florida.** Board Friday November 20. Ship leaves 4:00 PM
2. **At sea.** Saturday November 21
3. **Puerto Plata (Amber Cove), Dominican Republic.** Sunday November 22, 9:00 AM to 4:00 PM
4. **St. Thomas, US Virgin Islands.** Monday November 23, 11:00 AM to 7:00 PM
5. **Tortola, British Virgin Islands.** Tuesday November 24, 6:45 AM to 2:00 PM
6. **At sea.** Wednesday November 25
7. **Great Stirrup Cay, Bahamas.** Thursday November 26, **Thanksgiving Day**, 10:00 AM to 6:00 PM
8. **Port Canaveral.** Arrive Friday November 27, 7:00 AM

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All aboard is one hour before the ship leaves. NCL's rule is that you must be back on board "no later than one (1) hour prior to the ship's scheduled departure time." So: 3:00 PM at Port Canaveral and Puerto Plata, 6:00 PM in St. Thomas, **1:00 PM in Tortola**, and 5:00 PM at Great Stirrup Cay.

Tortola is a short, early day. The ship is in from 6:45 AM and you need to be back by 1:00 PM. Plan it as a morning.

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Section 1 — Your Ship: Norwegian Escape

The first of her class, just refreshed

Norwegian Escape was built by Meyer Werft in Papenburg, Germany. The shipyard's release says NCL took delivery on October 22, 2015, at a ceremony in Bremerhaven, "after a building period of only 18 months," and calls her "the first ship in the company's new Breakaway Plus Class." She was christened at PortMiami on November 9, 2015, with the musician Pitbull as her godfather, as NCL announced at the time (Cruise Industry News). Her sisters in the class are **Norwegian Joy**, **Norwegian Bliss** and **Norwegian Encore**.

Gross tonnage, 164,998 for her, isn't a weight. The International Maritime Organization says it "is a function of the moulded volume of all enclosed spaces of the ship." Divide it by NCL's guest count and you get about 39 gross tons per guest. The **Ship Size Atlas** lines her up against other ships.

The late-October 2026 refresh. NCL's ship page lists four changes: Vibe Beach Club "is expanding," "Palomar is joining Norwegian Escape's lineup of world-class restaurants," a "new Starbucks location in the Atrium," and a pickleball court. NCL hasn't said where Palomar goes or whether it replaces anything, and its "What's On Board" page hadn't caught up when this was written. Check the app.

What's on board

These come from NCL's "What's On Board" page for Escape, read October 2026, before the refresh. Check the app for the current line-up.

- **Included restaurants: The Manhattan Room** (Deck 7), **Taste** and **Savor** (Deck 6), the **Garden Café** buffet (Deck 16), the **American Diner** (Deck 17), and **O'Sheehan's Neighborhood Bar & Grill** (Deck 7).
- **Specialty restaurants (extra): Cagney's Steakhouse**, **Food Republic**, **La Cucina**, **Bayamo by Ocean Blue**, **Moderno Churrascaria** and **Pincho Tapas Bar** on Deck 8, and **Teppanyaki** and **Le Bistro** on Deck 6. NCL's page gives a cover charge of $40 to $60 a person, and its gratuity FAQ adds a 20% charge to specialty dining. **Palomar** joins after the refresh.

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- **Bars:** among others, **Spice H2O** (Deck 17, adults only), the **Sugarcane Mojito Bar**, **The Cellars Wine Bar**, The District Brew House and Tobacco Road, all on Deck 8.
- **Shows:** the Escape Theater, **Headliners Comedy Club** and The Supper Club. NCL's page lists shows including The Choir of Man and Howl at the Moon. It doesn't publish showtimes per sailing, so check the app.
- **Outdoors:** the Ropes Course (Deck 18), the Aqua Park (Deck 16) with the Aqua Racer and Free Fall slides (Deck 20), mini golf (Deck 18), and **The Waterfront**, the outdoor promenade on Deck 8.
- **Spa and fitness:** the Mandara Spa and the Pulse Fitness Center (Deck 16). The spa's **Thermal Suite** needs its own paid pass, and NCL says guests must be 18 or older for spa services.
- **Vibe Beach Club** on Deck 19 is adults only and needs a paid pass. It's one of the spaces NCL is expanding.

Cabin choice: sailing solo

Escape is one of the NCL ships with **Studio** cabins and the **Studio Lounge**. NCL's page lists the Studio Lounge on Deck 11 and says it's "exclusive to Studio guests." NCL's solo page lists complimentary coffee, espresso and snacks there, and keycard access. On Escape's deck plans, NCL's Solo Studio is listed at 99 square feet.

Escape's deck plans also list **Solo Inside, Solo Oceanview and Solo Balcony** cabins, each "exclusively for one guest," and each with access to the Studio Lounge. So whatever solo cabin you're in, the lounge is yours too.

Pam's group flyer priced three cabins: **Solo Studio $1,249**, **Ocean View $1,569** and **Balcony $1,839**. Tina has the current numbers and what's bundled with them.

The **stateroom check** can tell you about a specific cabin number. On most Norwegian ships its cabin list is still partial, and it says so.

Free at Sea

For bookings made from November 5, 2025, NCL's package is called **Free at Sea**. Per NCL's Free at Sea page, read October 2026, it includes:

- An **open bar** for guests 21 and over, on board and at Great Stirrup Cay

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- **Specialty dining**: NCL's table gives **three meals on a 7- or 8-night cruise**
- **Wi-Fi**: 150 minutes
- A **$50 shore excursion credit** at each port, for the first guest in the cabin

The open bar isn't free of charges. NCL's own Free at Sea flyer (December 2025) says: "Gratuities are $28.50/per person/per day for all Guests 21+. Please note this is the pre-cruise price. The onboard price will vary." For seven nights, that's **about $200**, on top of the daily service charge. A group booking can bundle things differently, so **check your own confirmation with Tina**. The **drink calculator** uses the same $28.50.

Connectivity

NCL's Wi-Fi runs on Starlink. Free at Sea includes 150 minutes. Beyond that, NCL's Free at Sea page lists the **Voyage Wi-Fi Pass at $29.99** and the **Streaming Voyage Wi-Fi Pass at $39.99**, each per cabin per day, plus $14.99 a day for each extra device (October 2026). The **internet at sea guide** explains how ship Wi-Fi works.

Section 2 — Day by Day

Each port day has the times from NCL's schedule, the all-aboard time, and a few things to know. The port pages on this site go deeper.

> ***This is not your plan.*** *What follows is one possible shape of the week, not a schedule to keep. Only a few things on it are actually fixed: the muster drill, sailaway, the ship's arrival and all-aboard times in each port, and anything you have already booked. Everything else is a suggestion you are free to ignore, reorder, or sleep through. A day spent entirely on your balcony is not a day wasted, and nothing here is a commitment you have made to anyone.*

Day 1 — Friday, November 20 — Port Canaveral (embarkation)

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Ship leaves: 4:00 PM. **Be on board by 3:00 PM.**

- **The terminal.** NCL's Port Canaveral page says: "NCL typically sails out of Cruise Terminal 5 (CT5) and Cruise Terminal 6 (CT6), but this is subject to change." **Your eDocs name yours.**
- **Parking.** Port Canaveral's own page says parking is "$20.00 per day plus tax," counting both the day you arrive and the day you leave. It's paid when you drive in, by credit card only (no cash), and the port says, "We do not take parking reservations." Seven nights is eight days of parking.
- **Arrival time.** NCL asks guests who've checked in online to arrive at the terminal no later than one hour before their chosen boarding time.
- **Carry-on.** Keep your ID documents, medications, a swimsuit and a change of clothes with you. NCL asks you to carry a small bag with what you need on the first day "while your luggage is delivered" to your cabin.
- **Sailaway with the group.** Pam posts the meeting spot in the Facebook chat. Spice H2O at the stern (adults only) and The Waterfront on Deck 8 are both outdoors.

Flying in. Fly in the day before, Thursday November 19, so a late flight doesn't cost you the cruise.

More on the **Port Canaveral port page**.

Day 2 — Saturday, November 21 — At sea

The first sea day. Book your specialty dinners and any shore excursions you still want, find the Studio Lounge if you're in a solo cabin, and sleep in if you like. The Ropes Course and the Aqua Park are both up top.

Day 3 — Sunday, November 22 — Puerto Plata (Amber Cove), Dominican Republic

In port: 9:00 AM to 4:00 PM. **All aboard 3:00 PM.**

- **The pier.** NCL's port page lists the Amber Cove Cruise Terminal and says the ship will dock. Amber Cove's own site puts it on the Bay of Maimón, on the Dominican Republic's north coast.

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- **What to do.** NCL sells Shore Excursions from here, and this site's **Amber Cove page** has more.
- **Money.** NCL says the local currency is the Dominican peso. Ask before you pay in dollars.
- **Emergency number:** 911. The UK government notes that 911 "does not have full coverage across the country."
- **Travel advisory.** The US State Department rates the Dominican Republic Level 2, "exercise increased caution" (June 2025).

Day 4 — Monday, November 23 — St. Thomas, US Virgin Islands

In port: 11:00 AM to 7:00 PM. **All aboard 6:00 PM.**

A late-morning arrival and an evening departure, so you have the afternoon.

- **Which dock.** Charlotte Amalie has two cruise docks. The Virgin Islands Port Authority runs Crown Bay; the West Indian Company runs the dock at Havensight. The Port Authority's Crown Bay schedule for this period doesn't list Escape on November 23, which points to Havensight, but NCL doesn't say. **Check the app.**
- **It's US territory.** NCL lists the currency as the US dollar. The emergency number is 911.
- **Magens Bay.** The beach is run by the Magens Bay Authority, which charges visitors an entry fee. VI Consortium reported that from October 1, 2023, the fee is $7 for non-residents over 12. Check before you go.
- More on the **St. Thomas port page**.

Day 5 — Tuesday, November 24 — Tortola, British Virgin Islands

In port: 6:45 AM to 2:00 PM. **All aboard 1:00 PM.**

The shortest day of the week, and the earliest. Plan a morning, not a day.

- **Dock or tender.** NCL's Tortola page lists Road Town Harbor and says the ship "will DOCK or ANCHOR OFF SHORE at this port." If she anchors, you go ashore by tender. **The app will say that morning**, and the last tender back leaves before all-aboard time.
- **Money.** NCL lists the currency as the US dollar.

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- **Emergency number:** 911 for ambulance, fire and police. The UK government's travel advice also gives 767 for Virgin Islands Search and Rescue, for emergencies at sea.
- **US help.** The BVI has no US embassy. The CIA World Factbook names the US Embassy in Bridgetown, Barbados as the contact, and that embassy's own site gives its after-hours line as 1-246-227-4000.
- **Travel advisory.** The US State Department rates the BVI Level 1, "exercise normal precautions" (May 2026).
- More on the **Tortola port page**.

Day 6 — Wednesday, November 25 — At sea

The second sea day, and the day before Thanksgiving. A good day for the Thermal Suite, a show, or a long lunch, and a good night to call home if tomorrow will be hard.

Day 7 — Thursday, November 26 — Great Stirrup Cay, Bahamas (Thanksgiving Day)

In port: 10:00 AM to 6:00 PM. **All aboard 5:00 PM.**

This is NCL's own island in the Bahamas, and you're here for Thanksgiving.

- **The pier.** NCL says a multi-ship pier debuted in December 2025. When it opened, NCL said all ships visiting the island will benefit from it, with "guests no longer being required to tender from ship to shore" (quoted by Cruise Industry News). In September 2026 Cruise Industry News reported that "the new pier opened in August 2026." So expect to walk ashore, and **check the app** the day before.
- **What's free:** the beaches, loungers and umbrellas, and the Splash Harbor splash pad. The Free at Sea open bar applies on the island.
- **What costs extra:** the **Great Tides Waterpark**, which opened in September 2026, was "from $89" on NCL's excursion page in October 2026. Also cabanas, the Vibe Shore Club day pass, the zipline, and snorkel and paddleboard rentals.
- **Money.** NCL's ships use US dollars, charged to your shipboard account. NCL lists your key card among the things to bring to the waterpark.
- **Thanksgiving evening** is back on board. See **Section 12**. If you'd like a shower and a rest before dinner, leave the island early; all aboard is 5:00 PM.

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More on the **Great Stirrup Cay port page**.

Day 8 — Friday, November 27 — Port Canaveral (debarkation)

The ship is due in at 7:00 AM. Keep your ID, medications and a change of clothes with you. Since she isn't due until 7:00 AM, **don't book an early-morning flight.** It's also Black Friday, so leave extra time on the roads.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

Now (five weeks out)

- **Check your documents.** For a round trip from a US port, NCL accepts a valid passport, or a state-certified US birth certificate with a government photo ID. NCL also says it "strongly recommends all guests to obtain a passport."
- **Buy travel insurance** if you haven't. Medical care on board is billed to you.
- **Join the Facebook chat.** That's where Pam's plans arrive.
- **Ask Tina** what your group rate includes: Free at Sea, prepaid service charges, anything else.

When NCL opens your bookings

- **Specialty dinners**, if Free at Sea gives you three. If you want one on Thanksgiving night, book it early.
- **Shore excursions,** if you want any.
- **Great Tides Waterpark** tickets, if you want them. NCL sells them as an excursion.

When NCL opens online check-in

- **Check in** in the NCL app, and choose your boarding time.

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- **Book your flight in for Thursday, November 19.**

The week before

- **Fill in the handoff card** in **Section 6** and give it to one person at home.
- **Count down** with the **countdown tool**, if that helps.

Section 4 — Packing List

This list fits **late November in the Caribbean**: warm days, a chance of showers, four port days and two sea days. The **packing lists** page has more.

Documents and money

- **Passport** (or the birth certificate and photo ID NCL allows)
- A copy of your passport, kept somewhere else
- Your insurance policy and its emergency number, printed
- Two cards, kept in different places
- Some small US bills for taxis and tips ashore

Carry-on

- All medications, in their original bottles
- Phone, charger, power bank
- Refillable water bottle
- Swimsuit and a change of clothes

Daytime

- Swimsuits and a cover-up
- Light shirts and shorts

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- A light sweater for the air conditioning
- A light rain jacket
- Sunglasses, hat, reef-safe sunscreen

Evenings

NCL's restaurant dress code: "shirts and footwear required," and "swimwear should be saved for the pool." Pack whatever makes you comfortable at dinner within that. If you'd like to dress up a little for Thanksgiving dinner, bring one thing for it.

Footwear

- Walking shoes for Charlotte Amalie and Road Town
- Water shoes for the beaches
- Sandals

Wine

NCL lets you carry on bottles of wine and champagne, but not box wine or other alcohol. Its corkage fee is $15 per 750 ml bottle, waived if you have a drink package.

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

Prices here were checked in **October 2026**. Use them to plan, and check again before you go. For your own total, the **cruise budget calculator** is set up for this.

Included in an NCL fare

- Your cabin
- Meals at the included restaurants (the Manhattan Room, Taste, Savor, the Garden Café, the American Diner, O'Sheehan's)

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- The shows in the Escape Theater
- Pools, the Aqua Park and the fitness center
- At Great Stirrup Cay: the beaches, loungers and splash pad
- Whatever Free at Sea, or your group rate, adds (see **Section 1**)

What might cost extra

Item	What we know (October 2026)
Daily service charge	$20 per person per day for cabins up to Club Balcony Suite; $25 for The Haven and suites (bookings from January 1, 2023). For 7 nights, $140 in a standard cabin. It can be prepaid up to 24 hours before sailing. Ask Tina whether your group rate prepaid it
Drink package service charge	$28.50 per person per day for guests 21 and over with the Free at Sea open bar (NCL's flyer, pre-cruise price; NCL says the onboard price will vary). About $200 for seven nights
Drinks without a package	NCL adds 20% to bar purchases
Specialty dining	$40 to $60 a person cover charge, plus 20%, beyond your Free at Sea meals
Wi-Fi	Beyond Free at Sea's 150 minutes: $29.99 a day per cabin, or $39.99 for streaming; $14.99 a day per extra device
Thermal Suite, Vibe Beach Club	Paid passes
Great Stirrup Cay	Great Tides Waterpark from $89; cabanas and rentals extra
Magens Bay, St. Thomas	An entry fee for visitors ($7 from October 2023, per VI Consortium)
Parking	$20 a day plus tax at Port Canaveral; eight days for this sailing
Laundry	Steward service, priced on the form in your cabin; express same-day available

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Item	What we know (October 2026)
Travel insurance	Depends on age and coverage
Hotel the night before	Depends on prices that week

Tipping

NCL’s daily service charge covers the crew in general. The **cruise tipping calculator** helps if you want to plan anything extra, and **Cruise Tipping 2026** explains the custom.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Fill this in and give a copy to one person at home before you go. When you’re sailing alone, this card is how they find you.

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FAMILY HANDOFF — IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK
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CRUISER:          _____________________
CABIN:            ____________
SHIP:             Norwegian Escape
LINE:             Norwegian Cruise Line
SAILING:          November 20 – 27, 2026
                  (Thanksgiving cruise)
FROM:             Port Canaveral, Florida, USA
ITINERARY:        Port Canaveral → at sea →
                  Puerto Plata (DR) → St. Thomas (USVI) →
                  Tortola (BVI) → at sea →
                  Great Stirrup Cay (Bahamas) →
                  Port Canaveral
GROUP HOST:       Pam Walters
                  Thanksgiving Group Cruise FB chat:
                  facebook.com/share/1DuHTTtgdc
DAILY CHECK-IN:   I'll message by _______ each evening
                  (ship time). No message by _______ ?
                  Follow the steps below.

EMERGENCY (24/7):
  US Citizens Abroad – State Dept:
                  +1 (888) 407-4747  (from the US/Canada)
                  +1 (202) 501-4444  (from abroad)
  To reach someone aboard an NCL ship:
                  1-833-810-7963   (from the US/Canada)
                  1-321-953-9006   (international)
                  (NCL says calls are paid by card)
  Booking agent – Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel:
                  910-528-5077
                  tina@maulsbytravel.com

EMERGENCY NUMBERS ASHORE:
  Port Canaveral, FL  – 911
  Puerto Plata, DR    – 911 (not full coverage)
  St. Thomas, USVI    – 911
  Tortola, BVI        – 911; at sea, VISAR 767
  Great Stirrup Cay   – 911 or 919 (Bahamas)

US EMBASSIES (24/7 emergency lines):
  Dominican Republic – Embassy Santo Domingo:
                       (809) 567-7775
  BVI                – Embassy Bridgetown, Barbados:
                       1-246-227-4000 (after hours)
  Bahamas            – Embassy Nassau:
                       242-461-5025, ext 1
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CRUISER MEDICAL:
  Allergies:    _____________________
  Medications:  _____________________
  Conditions:   _____________________
  Insurance:    _____________________  policy: ____________

WHERE IS THE SHIP:
  cruisinginthewake.com/tools/ship-tracker.html
_____________________________________________
```

What the person at home should do

If they don’t hear from you by the check-in time:

1. **Don’t panic.** A missed message isn’t, by itself, a sign of trouble.
2. **Wait for the next check-in.** Then try your phone and messages.
3. **Ask Tina or Pam.** Tina is the group’s booking agent; Pam is on the ship and in the Facebook chat.
4. **Call NCL’s ship number** above. NCL says it’s paid by card.
5. **If it’s serious,** call the State Department: +1 (888) 407-4747. US embassy sites say Americans who need help can call it 24/7.
6. **To see where the ship is,** use the **ship tracker**.

The page on **reaching someone at sea** explains how all this works.

Where these numbers come from. The State Department numbers and the Santo Domingo and Nassau lines are from each US embassy’s own website; the Bridgetown line is from that embassy’s contact page, and the CIA World Factbook names it as the contact for the BVI. NCL’s ship number is from NCL’s FAQ. The local emergency numbers are from the UK government’s travel advice. Tina’s contact details are from the group’s booking information. Check them again before you go.

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Section 7 — Weather and Seasickness

Weather

NOAA publishes official climate normals for US weather stations, worked out from 1991 to 2020. Two of your stops have one. These are the averages for November 20 to 27, not a forecast. The companion app shows a real forecast as the dates get close.

Stop	NOAA station	Typical high	Typical low	Chance of rain on a given day
Port Canaveral	Melbourne airport, about 20 miles south	76°F	59°F	26%
St. Thomas	St. Thomas airport	86°F	76°F	58%

“Chance of rain” is NOAA’s figure for 0.01 inch or more in a day, so a passing shower counts. Read it as how often you might see rain, not how often a day is spoiled.

Puerto Plata, Tortola and Great Stirrup Cay have no NOAA normals, and the weather service this site uses for averages was over its daily limit when this pack was checked, so this pack leaves them blank rather than guess. Tortola sits about 20 miles east of St. Thomas. The companion app’s forecast covers all five stops from about two weeks out.

Hurricanes. NOAA says the season ends November 30, three days after you’re home. NCL’s own terms say “itineraries are subject to change without notice.”

Seasickness

Nobody can promise how your body will feel at sea. If you’re prone to seasickness:

- **Think about where your cabin is.** A ship pitches and rolls around its middle, so a cabin low and near the middle moves the least.
- **Ask your doctor or pharmacist** about meclizine, dimenhydrinate or a prescription scopolamine patch, which the CDC names, and try anything new at home first.

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- **Ginger and acupressure bands:** the CDC says ginger has “only weak and contradictory supporting evidence,” and that bands are “no more effective than placebo” in laboratory trials.
- **Fresh air and a view of the horizon:** the CDC says a visible horizon gives “some protection” on ships, and suggests fresh air as a distraction.
- **The ship’s medical center** can treat seasickness. It bills you. Medicare’s own guide says it “doesn’t cover health care services you get when the ship is more than 6 hours away from a U.S. port,” so check what your plan covers.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

Phones

- **At sea:** use the ship’s Wi-Fi, and turn off cellular data so you don’t pay for the ship’s network.
- **St. Thomas** is US territory. **Puerto Plata, Tortola and Great Stirrup Cay** are outside the US. Some US plans include them, some charge a daily fee. **Check with your carrier before you go.**

Money

- **Aboard:** US dollars, on your shipboard account (NCL).
- **Puerto Plata:** the Dominican peso (NCL).
- **St. Thomas:** the US dollar (NCL).
- **Tortola:** the US dollar (NCL).
- **Great Stirrup Cay:** your shipboard account.

Travel advisories (US State Department)

Read October 2026:

- **Dominican Republic:** Level 2, “exercise increased caution” (June 2025).

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- **British Virgin Islands:** Level 1, “exercise normal precautions” (May 2026).
- **The Bahamas:** Level 2, “exercise increased caution” (July 2026).

St. Thomas is part of the United States. Levels change. The companion app’s Alerts tab shows the current level for each, refreshed daily.

Laundry, smoking, and the rules

- **Laundry.** Not self-service. Use the order form in your cabin; express same-day service is available.
- **Smoking** in your cabin or on your balcony carries a **$250 cleaning charge**, per NCL’s FAQ. Escape has The Humidor Cigar Lounge; ask on board where else smoking is allowed.
- **Drinking age:** 21 on sailings from the US.

Accessibility

If you use a wheelchair or a scooter, or need other help, tell NCL when you book. Tortola may be a tender day (see **Day 5**). Great Stirrup Cay now has a pier, but check the app that day. The **accessibility guide** on this site covers more.

Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

Pam Walters is your on-ship host, and the Thanksgiving Group Cruise Facebook chat is where the plans live. How the week usually goes with the group:

- **Day 1 sailaway.** Pam names a meeting spot in the chat.
- **Group dinners.** Pam posts the time and place in the chat. Come to the ones that suit you.
- **The Studio Lounge.** If you’re in a solo cabin, it’s yours too, and it’s an easy place to find other solo travelers.

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- **Thanksgiving dinner (Day 7).** Pam's plan for the holiday meal will be in the chat. See **Section 12**.
- **Port days.** Do your own thing, or ask in the chat who's going where.

If you're shy. You don't have to go to every gathering. Come to one dinner, see how it feels, and decide from there.

Section 10 — Sailing Solo on Escape

- **Solo cabins.** Escape has Studios and Solo Inside, Oceanview and Balcony cabins, each for one guest.
- **The Studio Lounge** (Deck 11) is for solo-cabin guests, with coffee, espresso and snacks, per NCL.
- **Eat where it's easy.** The Garden Café buffet and O'Sheehan's let you eat on your own schedule.
- **Excursions.** NCL's Shore Excursions are an easy way to spend a port day with other people.

Safety, the same as at home: tell someone where you're going ashore, keep your drink in sight, and be back early.

The **solo cruising hub** has more from people who've done it.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise, the **first-cruise guide** goes deeper. A few things worth knowing ahead:

- **Download the NCL app** and log in before you go.

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- **Be back early.** NCL says that if you miss the ship, “it will be the guest’s responsibility to pay all expenses incurred to rejoin the ship.” Tortola’s 1:00 PM all-aboard is the one to watch.
- **You don’t have to do everything.** A week is long enough to skip things.

If you like photos, the **cruise tech and photography guide** helps you pack the right gear.

Section 12 — Thanksgiving Aboard

The holiday is the reason this group exists, so it gets its own section.

What NCL says

NCL’s Thanksgiving page promises “festive menus without the stress.” That’s as specific as it gets. NCL doesn’t publish a Thanksgiving menu, which restaurants serve it, or the times, so this pack doesn’t guess. **Check the daily schedule in the app that morning.** The specialty restaurants are there if you’d rather not have the traditional meal; if you want one that night, book it early.

The group

Pam’s plan for the holiday dinner, the time and the place, will be in the Facebook chat.

The 5 PM moment

For a lot of solo Thanksgiving cruisers, the hardest minute of the day comes around 4:30 or 5:00 PM ship time. Back home, the family is sitting down. The grandkids are at the table. The chair you usually sit in is filled by someone else, or it’s empty. You can feel that from a ship in the Bahamas.

This is the part nobody briefs you for, and this pack won’t pretend it doesn’t happen.

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Some options for that hour:

- **Go to Pam's group dinner.** Others at that table may be feeling the same thing at the same hour. A full table is the Thanksgiving this cruise can give you.
- **Step away if you need to.** Tears at the rail on Thanksgiving aren't weakness. Take ten minutes. Call home on the ship's Wi-Fi if you can, send a message if you can't. Then come down to dinner.
- **Skip dinner entirely if that's the answer.** The cabin door locks and the pillow is yours. If you came so you wouldn't have to perform a celebration, that's a fair way to spend this trip too.

You don't have to explain anything to anyone.

Closing

This pack is a plain read on one week: a just-refreshed ship, a Dominican port, two of the Virgin Islands, and NCL's own island on Thanksgiving Day. Check the numbers again before you go, set your own pace, and let Pam's group be as much or as little of the week as you want.

Share or save. The companion app has a share button. If someone you know is in the group, send them the link.

Soli Deo Gloria. All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent: no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped you, that's the whole point.

Safe sailing, and Happy Thanksgiving.

Last reviewed | 2026-10-13, for a sailing on 2026-11-20. Rebuilt against primary sources; sailing times and ship facts from NCL's own pages, port facts as noted below | How facts here are checked | Every fact in this pack is listed with its source in the pack's fact-check file. The sailing's dates, port order and times come from NCL's schedule for this voyage. Ship facts come from NCL's ship page, "What's On Board"

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page, deck plans, FAQ and Free at Sea page, Meyer Werft's delivery release, and the ship's Wikipedia entry (for tonnage, citing DNV). Port facts come from NCL, Port Canaveral, the Virgin Islands Port Authority, Amber Cove, the US State Department and its embassy sites, the CIA World Factbook and the UK government's travel advice, with named newspapers and trade press where those had no answer. Weather averages are NOAA's 1991 to 2020 climate normals, for the two stops that have a NOAA station. Group details (Pam, the Facebook chat, the group rates, Tina's contact details) come from the group's own booking information. Where sources disagreed, the pack says so or leaves the number out. |

Accessibility | This pack is written to read straight through on a screen reader: headings in order, small labeled tables, and links named for where they go. If something here is hard for you to use, that's a bug, and we want to hear about it. Tell Tina, or post in the group chat. |

Sources | Ship: **Norwegian Escape**; NCL ship page, "What's On Board", deck plans, FAQ, Free at Sea and solo pages; Meyer Werft (delivery, 22 October 2015); Cruise Industry News (christening announcement, 2015; drydock, October 2026). Ports on this site: **Port Canaveral**, **Amber Cove**, **St. Thomas**, **Tortola**, **Great Stirrup Cay**. Venues: **The Manhattan Room**, **Taste**, **Savor**, **Garden Café**, **American Diner**, **O'Sheehan's**, **Cagney's**, **Food Republic**, **La Cucina**, **Bayamo by Ocean Blue**, **Moderno**, **Pincho Tapas Bar**, **Teppanyaki**, **Le Bistro**, **Palomar**, **Spice H2O**, **Studio Lounge**, **Vibe Beach Club**. Tools: **drink calculator**, **stateroom check**, **cruise budget calculator**, **cruise tipping calculator**, **ship tracker**, **ship size atlas**. Reference: **solo cruising hub**, **first-cruise guide**, **countdown**, **packing lists**, **internet at sea**, **reaching someone at sea**, **disability at sea**. Articles: **Cruise Tipping 2026**, **cruise tech and photography guide**. Image: Norwegian Escape at Nassau, by Syrus257 (CC BY 2.0), via Wikimedia Commons. |

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